defeat. The decision to start a nuclear war in which hundreds of millions of people would die would rest on the shoulders of the forty-three-year-old president. Responsibility for forcing that decision lay with his sixty-eight-year-old adversary.

Meanwhile, as Castro and his comrades consolidated their revolution, US military contingency planning, US covert action, and CIA assassination plotting, continued over the next year. When, in the aftermath of the Bay of Pigs fiasco, Robert Kennedy raised the prospect of Soviet nuclear missiles in Cuba, few in Washington believed that Khrushchev would take such a risk, even as many in Havana and Moscow took seriously the prospect of further US intervention in Cuba. From the US perspective, the Bay of Pigs was a concatenation of misperceptions, misjudgements, and mistakes. For a nuclear-armed superpower in confrontation with another nuclear-armed superpower the prospect of such miscalculations was a matter of deep concern.